personalised agent and experiencer subject to *Vedic* social and ritual duties (*varna-ashrama-dharma*) and transmigration (***samsara***). The human person is a composite of spirit (***atman***) and matter. Such a composite has experiences and is subject to the illusion that it is an agent. This denial that the self is really an agent is crucial to ***Advaita Vedanta***. Aversion to worldly life, and renunciation (***samnyasa***) of all ritual and ***caste*** duty precedes direct insight (***jnana-marga***) into the identity of the soul and ***Brahman***. That intuition negates ***avidya*** and alone leads to release (***moksha***) from the series of births. Insight into the ***Brahman-atman*** state only arises from the accredited scriptures (***shruti***), which are the only means of knowledge about supernatural realities. Liberating insight is expressed in *Upanishadic* major statements such as 'That thou art' (*Tat tvam asi*), asserting the identity of the self and the Absolute.

Ritual action (***karman***) and devotion (*bhakti*), while purifying the mind, cannot of themselves produce release since they presuppose that differences are real and thus belong in the sphere of ignorance. In short, any form of action binds one to ***samsara***.

The human life of the enlightened and liberated individual (*jivanmukta*) continues until what is termed the ***karma*** appropriate to the final existence has been exhausted. No fresh ***karma*** is generated after the renunciation of all ritually and ethically significant actions.

See ***Neti Neti***, ***adhyasa***

Further reading: Bartley 2002; Halbfass 1995; Mayeda 1979; Potter 1981; Ram-Prasad 2002; Thibaut 1904b

Shantarakshita (c. 700–50 CE): Buddhist philosopher whose *Tattvasamgraha* is an elaborate defence of the logical and epistemological theories of idealist ***Vijnanavada***. This comprehensive work, with its commentary by